ate or to bridge the significant gap between the INDIA bloc's 35.6 per cent vote share and the NDA's commanding 45.5 per cent in the Lok Sabha election. For Tejaswi, the road ahead is fraught with challenges. While his tenure as deputy CM showed promise in terms of expanding his party's appeal among peripheral backward communities, Verma notes that the RJD leader is yet to make significant inroads into the numerically significant *ati-pichhda* (most backward) voter base, which remains loyal to Nitish.

Complicating matters further is the entry of new players like poll strategist-turned-politician Prashant Kishor's Jan Suraaj Party (JSP), which threatens to fragment the vote bank even further. Already, as seen in Belaganj, the JSP's Mohammad Amajad was able to secure a sizeable 17,000-plus votes, eating into the RJD's traditional Muslim base. Any further erosion in the party's already fragile M-Y combination could prove catastrophic.

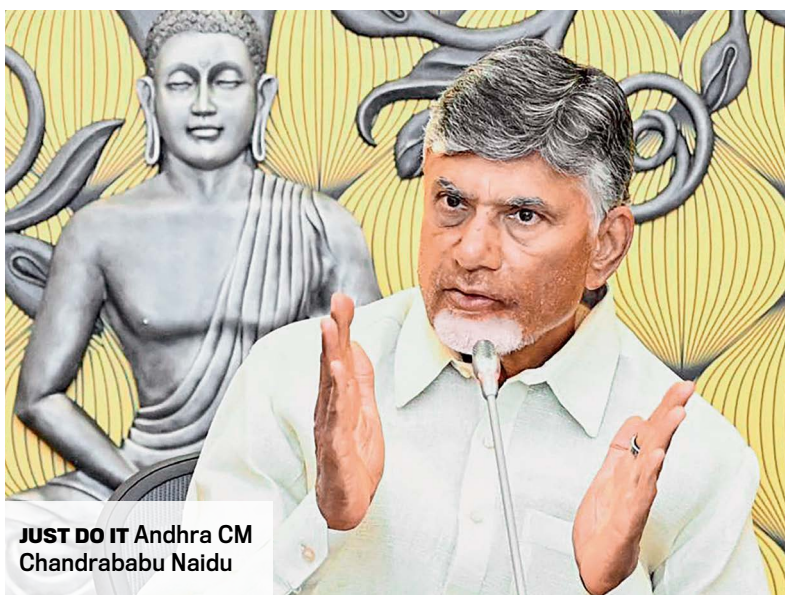
WITH YOUNG VOTERS PRIORITISING JOBS AND DEVELOPMENT, TEJASWI MUST BALANCE LEGACY POLITICS WITH A FORWARD-LOOKING VISION FOR THE 2025 ASSEMBLY ELECTION

Tejaswi's ability to navigate these turbulent waters will define not only his political destiny but also that of the RJD in a state known for its volatile politics. The stakes could not have been higher. With the assembly election looming, Tejaswi faces a critical question: can he revitalise the RJD's legacy while presenting a forward-looking vision that resonates with Bihar's diverse electorate? Or will his efforts remain, like his reservation pitch, a reflection of past glories? One thing is certain: the battle for Bihar's future will be as much about ideas and leadership as it is about numbers and alliances. ■

ANDHRA PRADESH

Naidu Says More the Merrier

By Amarnath K. Menon



JUST DO IT Andhra CM Chandrababu Naidu

ANI

The Andhra Pradesh government has repealed a 30-year-old rule that had made the two-child norm mandatory for those seeking election to local bodies such as the gram panchayats, mandal praja parishads and zilla parishads. The state assembly scrapped the AP Panchayat Raj (Amendment) Bill and the AP Municipal Laws (Amendment) Bill on November 18. The bills were part of many passed in India in line with the family planning initiative pushed vigorously since the 1970s.

Over the past three decades, Andhra's population growth rate has declined; in fact, by 2021, it had come down to 1.5 (the replacement fertility rate to keep a population steady is considered to be 2.1). The state is now among those with the least growth in population. This will over time result in a skewed demographic composition, says the government.

Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu has been advocating that after all the early success of family planning policies—even as a necessary corollary to that—it is now time to incentivise women and families to have more children. At a recent public event in capital Amravati, Naidu said, "I want to tell the women here—if you have less